



Adopting the new

US Major Kathleen Wilkes and Sergeant First Class Betty Adams look on as new recruits to South Vietnam's Women's Army Corps trade their *ao dai* (a traditional dress that fell out of favor in North Vietnam) for ARVN uniforms.

South Vietnam

The political situation in South Vietnam demanded that women choose sides, with some supporting the Saigon government, others supporting the Viet Cong, and most just trying to survive. Many soldiers in the South Vietnamese Army (ARVN) kept their families with them in the field, and thousands of women therefore acted as "soldiers without serial numbers," even defending camps against Viet Cong attack.

Starting in 1965, women could also serve in the Women's Armed Forces Corps, an ARVN auxiliary that relegated women to support roles. In the Viet Cong, on the other hand, women provided logistic support, medical care, and intelligence but also fought in the "long-haired army."